

PERCEPTION, DETERMINATION, LOVE AS ASPECTS OF CONSCIOUSNESS

Greetings my dearest friends. Blessing for each one of you. Blessed be this hour. May all my friends continue to grow and to develop, for this is the essence of life itself. Where there is no growth, there is no life. This does not apply to the physical manifestation of life, but to the source itself. There are, of course, different stages and manners in the growing process. In some instances, it is so indirect and gradual, with the person being unaware even of the concept of possibility of inner growth, so that it can be perceived only at a much later state of increased consciousness. If growing stops on any level of life, the respective manifestation of life ceases. But since spirit is eternal, it must potentially be growth. Therefore spirit cannot die. Its growth and unfoldment can be arrested only if its manifest forms are not in the process of growth and therefore not alive.

Life, as growth, exists in degrees. It cannot be said that something or someone is either alive or not alive, either in growth or not. There are many grades in between. Nonlife is nongrowth.

We have discussed life, its meaning, significance, definition, and manifestation, from many points of view. Each time I choose an angle to discuss of life -- or of any other topic, for that matter -- it is adjusted to the level that you have reached in the course of your development. It is best fitted to penetrate a deeper root of understanding in your soul, which is due to your progress. Through your work of self-search, deeper levels of understanding are opened up so that words of truth will directly reach these inner levels -- or have a chance of doing so. It is therefore important to discuss the same subjects from different vantage points at specific phases of your pathwork. What you have heretofore understood in a more shallow way will then be more profoundly comprehended as a result of your pathwork in conjunction with the proper meditation. These lectures can be regarded as such.

Man sometimes believes himself to be in a growing process, while he is merely going around in circles. Undirected or misdirected methods of self-confrontation often bring this about. In such a case, the person may be outwardly convinced he is growing simply because of his activities in this respect, but inwardly he lacks the feeling and conviction of his actual development. On the other hand, he who is truly in the process of growth may often temporarily be discouraged and believe he is going around in circles, while he is actually in the process of growth. In this case, this belief is superficial, while inwardly he experiences certain phases in which he literally sees his inner growth. He feels it. But at the beginning, this happens only after periods of apparent setbacks and relapses, after having found the same aspects, attitudes, and distortions over and over again -- forever finding them in a new connection, forever shedding new light on the same disturbances, forever deliberating on them in different expressions of thought. This fortifies and consolidates the recognitions. It widens and deepens their perception. It links them with other aspects of the personality. All my friends who are truly on the path have observed the spiral movement it pursues of coming around in a full circle and finding the same all over again. Yet, the second time, the finding and

comprehension of the content occurs on a deeper level than the first -- and the tenth time, on a still deeper level than the ninth. These circles get narrower and narrower until they meet at one basic point of disturbance that can then, and only then, be fully tackled, faced, understood, and come to terms with. In principle, the process is the same as my taking an important concept and deliberating about it from different angles. This, too, follows the spiral movement according to the capacity and level that you have reached. One might say they are two parallel spiral movements: one following through the disturbance; the other, the complementing true picture of the distortions. To the degree that you are aware of, and properly evaluate, the distortion, to that degree can the true picture be assimilated into the deeper regions of your personality.

Growth and stagnation often seem similar when superficially considered, because both follow circular movements. Only a closer perception and deep penetration into your self will show you the difference. It sometimes does happen that the same circle is followed through all over again before one can proceed from it into the next, narrower one. But whenever the transition from one circle to the next is made, the reality of the forward movement will fill you to the depth of your being. You will then know that you are not moving in a stationary circle.

We discussed various aspects and meanings of life. Let us again approach this topic, this time from still another viewpoint. Life exists if a number of factors prevail. As I said previously, for instance, life is movement; life is growth; life is consciousness -- and several more factors that all end up at one and the same point. But each of these points is still a separate and distinctive factor. The conglomeration of all of them together forms one whole, one organization. An organization is a conglomerate of several particles. The absence of any of these particles destroys, or at least seriously impedes, the organization as a whole. Think, for example, of a business firm, an organization in this respect. There are different officers, each fulfilling a certain task, each taking on certain responsibilities. If one drops out, he has to be replaced, for otherwise the organization could not function.

The same applies to the anatomy of the physical body. It, too, is an organization. The well-functioning body requires many working parts. If one is out of commission, depending on whether or not this part is a vital one, physical life ceases. In the case where it is not essential, then the efficacy of the physical body will be impaired.

Exactly the same law holds true for the inner organization of life. The average human being does not have all his inner faculties in good working order. As a result, his degree of awareness is below par, and he is, as the saying goes, only half alive, often even less than that.

The interaction between consciousness and aliveness (movement) is easily observable in the certain manifestations of nature. A mineral has a very small degree of consciousness, therefore its movement is almost imperceptible. A plant's degree of consciousness is higher than the mineral's. This is noticeable by its obvious responses to light, water, darkness, or dryness. And so its movement (of growth) is also more perceptible. And so it proceeds on the scale, from animal to human being. Now you may say that man's movement does not exceed the animal's. This is true on the physical level, but certainly when it comes to the movement of mind, thought, spirit, you will undoubtedly admit that man is more alive in that respect than the animal. The range of possibility for extension and movement of the spirit by far exceeds that of the body. Once this thought is truly understood in its full implication, any doubt about the continuation of life must cease. This will no

longer be a pleasant or unpleasant assumption and theory, but a logical sequence of an unbroken chain. There is no reason to assume that the chain should suddenly terminate.

Man's possibility to extend the range of consciousness is of course limited because of the confinement of his spirit. Only after he has fully utilized the range of extension available to him will such confinement no longer be a necessity. And only when man fully utilizes his possibilities in this regard will he be in harmony with himself and his life. If you view the pathwork from this angle, it may give you renewed incentive and strength through this more profound understanding.

Let us now discuss three distinctive facets, three major facets, that are part of the organization called life. These three aspects are direct manifestations of consciousness. They are determination, perception, and love. The higher the degree of consciousness, the wider is the range of life, the freer will be determination. It will not be hindered by the inner fetters we are trying to find and dissolve. You all know how your free will, or determination, is limited by your unconscious misconceptions. To the degree that you are capable of assimilating experience according to reality, according to truth, to that degree can you perceive, determine, and love.

A living creature is always the product, the sum total, of all his past experiences. How this experience is assimilated and understood in terms of reality determines the character, the thoughts, the opinions a person adopts and why, his feelings and emotions, his attitudes and inclinations. In other words, it determines the quality of his life. The more realistically and truthfully experience is interpreted and assimilated, the more accurate will be perception; the freer the determination (the greater the scope and ease with which decisions can be made); the greater the capacity to love, to relate.

It should be easy to see the interaction and interdependence of these three facets. For example, if you are relatively free of error, of misinterpreted past experience (free of images), you will have less destructive defenses. Therefore you can be more loving. This in turn will create good relationships which will afford you a wider range for experience, more possibilities, more inner and outer resources that give you a greater scope for determination. Even if you experience a disappointment, you will be able to see other opportunities. The disappointment will not paralyze your faculties and freeze your feelings into fear and distrust, such as happens with incorrectly assimilated experience. To understand the effect of this triad is of great importance. It will make even clearer than before why it is so important to find your images; to understand why they represent faulty perception; to see that this faulty perception still governs you even though it occurred when you were a child. You will see to what extent you are governed by this faulty perception, how it continues to impede proper interpretation and assimilation of new experiences, to which you react in the same way as you did in your childhood. You will understand how this continued faulty perception cripples your determination and the entire world of feeling.

You are bound by these old images, these faulty perceptions, which result in making you respond and react in an automatic way as though the new experience were similar in nature to the one that originally caused you to misinterpret a painful condition or occurrence. You saw it in a limited, one-sided way and generalized its validity for all similar occasions. The result is that you react in a way not appropriate to the occasion. You are unable to change this unless you bring this misinterpretation into consciousness and thoroughly understand why and in what way you have

misinterpreted. Only then will your responses be more adequate to, and compatible with, reality. This will free you from limitation and from frozen feelings.

When religious teachers preach about the importance of love, they are right, but love cannot fill your being if you do not perceive your wrong perceptions. No amount of proper knowledge you take in from the outside can be assimilated if you do not empty yourself of misconception. Therefore self-knowledge is the prerequisite to love, to spirituality. There is no way around that. No matter how much truth you try to imbibe, no matter how hard you try to feel what inwardly you are as yet incapable of feeling, your inner mechanisms are still geared to faulty or insufficiently assimilated material. This in turn forces you into reflexes so automatic, so limited that you cannot perceive in reality. Therefore you cannot determine as fully and widely as it were otherwise possible for you. And therefore you cannot feel the productive warm feelings, which all go under the heading of love, that create a benign circle of these three life aspects.

My friends, try to see how all your images limit your perception, your determination, and your love capacity. Try to see how the faulty perception responsible for the images squeezes you into a very limited mold, no matter what you consciously think and strive for. If you ponder your images from this angle, you will clearly see how your consciousness is diminished, as well as your feeling of being alive. The vibrancy of true aliveness is so very rare among human beings because most do not even search in the right direction.

The significance of misinterpreted material from the past cannot be stressed enough. The majority of human beings go through life never knowing to what an extent they are influenced in all their present-day dealings by their past. Even among my friends here, there are only a few who begin to fully realize the extent of past misinterpretation. They may be aware, to some degree, that such misinterpretation has taken place, but they cannot as yet fully grasp the impact of it.

Parents are the most important influence in a child's life. The relationship to them is of primary significance. Also, others who played an important role in a child's life -- such as teachers, siblings, or anyone closely related -- take a hand in forming the original impressions in the malleable soul substance. But all other people are only important in relationship to, and as determined by, the original relationship to the parents. Most of you yet need to realize to what a strong degree you carry this original relationship to both your parents into all your current life situations. Once you perceive this in all its significance, you will truly be liberated. But it requires a great deal of work, patience, perseverance, courage, and humility to follow through and arrive at this point.

The best way to experience the truth of these words is to take any of your findings; to consider your feelings as a child toward your parents; and then to see how your responses still react according to the same feelings you once harbored toward your parents -- for each parent in a different way. Only by working through this lecture on a very personal, practical basis, will you experience the truth. It cannot be done merely by believing this truth just because it makes sense. The new friends here, who are not involved with systematic work of self-finding, cannot possibly at this time understand in full measure.

The realization of your bondage to early reactions will free you of this bondage. Nothing else will, no matter how much knowledge (even spiritual knowledge) you try to collect from the outside. This awareness alone will raise your degree of consciousness and fill you with the vibrant feeling of

being truly alive. The only way awareness, and therefore your life, can grow is through these insights into your self. By becoming aware of your limitations, you eliminate the limitations. By becoming aware of your unreality, you live in greater reality. By becoming aware of your lack of love -- clothed perhaps in what appears to be love, but is not -- you will have more love. The feeling of strength, of well-being, of fulfillment, of trust in yourself, of security can grow only by facing that in you which you want to look away from. You are always tempted to look away from yourself.

Ever since mankind has existed, man has searched for security. The lack of it is perhaps the greatest factor responsible for all the misery man has managed to afflict on himself. This is so because he looks for it in the wrong way with the result that he is then disappointed and even more insecure and hopeless of ever finding it. He wishes to have his fears, anxieties, and uncertainties assuaged from the outside. But if this ever works, it only does so for a very limited time with the subsequent greater feeling of being let down.

When material security has been attained, only then does man discover that there is another type of insecurity within himself that he has not been able to recognize as long as he was preoccupied with the material side of life. For a while, he may succeed in looking away from the gnawing feeling of insecurity, clamoring for some alleviation. He may drown out this voice by all sorts of evasions, pleasurable or painful, constructive or destructive. But at some time, a reckoning must come that he can no longer avoid in order to confront his inner uncertainty. He must raise certain questions he has never dared to face. He must bring out exactly what it is he is so insecure about. But until such time, he often finds many ways of trying to still the clamoring voice by outer and therefore inadequate illusory means. The only realistic way of meeting his insecurity is, to begin with, by facing it, admitting it, accepting it, and then finding the inner answer through his understanding of the inner errors, misconceptions, faulty perceptions. This and only this will bring true security resting on firm ground that cannot be taken away by the storms of life.

As I implied before, looking in the illusory way for security from the outside need not necessarily be unconstructive. A person may try to escape from himself by doing good for society, by performing valuable scientific, artistic, or ethical works. Such pursuits are, in themselves, constructive and can help others. But they nevertheless go under the heading of escape because security cannot be found outside the self. He may, while performing such tasks, drown out his inner insecurity. But you will readily admit that drowning out is not a real solution. It is precarious and can crumble whenever something goes wrong. To find inner security in the real way does not mean that one has to cease doing good works. They can surely be continued while doing that which will establish the center of gravity within.

How can you love if you are insecure? It is not possible. Again, of course, there are degrees. Again, it is not a question of either/or. There are many areas in which a person is secure and therefore capable of love. But to the degree that insecurity permeates the soul, to that degree genuine capacity for loving is absent. Let us now connect inner security with love and evaluate various stages in the scale of the love capacity.

The basis of love is healthy self-love. We have gone into this extensively in the past and need not elaborate on it much further. But one thing you may note. If you are insecure, you cannot trust yourself. If you do not trust yourself, how can you love yourself? So you see, healthy self-love and

inner security are directly linked. And since love for others is dependent on healthy self-love, the former is equally dependent on and connected with inner security.

Let us now consider other stages of love. Lowest on the scale is surely love for inanimate objects. There are many whose sole outlet for the inherent need to display love does not dare go any further than loving inanimate objects. Objects do not oppose. They do not require the complicated mechanism of perceiving the feelings of others. They do not disapprove or criticize. They demand a minimum of personal sacrifice or consideration. Objects will make no demands.

Next on the scale is love for abstract ideas, principles, art, nature. The love for one's profession also falls into this category, although not necessarily exclusively. Love for abstract ideas also prevents personal contact and involvement with all accompanying apparent risks and insecurity. But at least, it moves the mind, the soul, or spirit in some measure. It may also require personal contact, confrontation with others of different opinions, involvement with other human beings to some degree, while love for objects may not necessitate this in any but the most rudimentary form. Love for ideas and principles is certainly more outgoing than the isolating pursuit of loving mere objects.

Next on the scale is love for living creatures other than man: plants or animals. They require a certain amount of sacrifice, consideration, putting aside one's immediate selfish comfort -- at least, occasionally if the love is active and not merely theoretical. It does not require the risk of rejection; nor the consideration of taking the trouble of pondering what the other's needs are; nor the effort of mutual understanding, of trying to understand, and of making oneself understood. To a very minor degree, these may also apply to keeping and caring for an animal, but certainly not to the degree that prevails in a close relationship with another human being wherein one's senses have to be alert to the other as well as to oneself if the relationship is a rewarding one.

Next on the scale is love for mankind as a whole. This may still relieve a person from intimate personal involvement -- the most taxing form of love and therefore the most fulfilling one. But it does require effort, thought, the willingness to sacrifice, activity, and many other attitudes that are highly constructive. Again this applies only if such love takes the form of following it through in practice rather than letting it simmer in theory only.

Highest on the human scale is the love for individuals in close, intimate relationship. I do not have to repeat why, for this was mentioned in connection with the other degrees of love on the lower rungs of the scale. If you ponder this question, you will find many other aspects why the latter is by far the most constructive and the highest on the scale. The fact that you and those you are involved with may often demonstrate this love by very turbulent manifestations does not alter the basic fact one bit. The fact that many manifestations of love have really nothing to do with genuine love, but are manifestations of immature needs and dependency and thus often bring rupture and disharmony, again does not alter the fact that such intercommunication furthers your general development and the capacity for genuine love. Such lives may be infinitely less harmonious than the life of a hermit, of a recluse right in the middle of your civilization -- I am speaking of the inner state -- but the process of growth cannot be measured by the outer harmony.

You may often find it comparatively easy to cope with the difficulty of relating with certain people but dread it with others. If this is so, do not fail to question yourself whether you do not run

from the very area in which you most need growth, just as others do who may perhaps withdraw outwardly even more obviously than you do. So beware of a quick, superficial evaluation of yourself and others. Only when you question your fears and insecurities, your reactions to those aspects of love that you wish to avoid, will you begin to sense a truthful answer. This will not harm you even should you decide to postpone exposing yourself to that which you still shrink away from. But at least, you will not deceive yourself about the level you have reached.

Some of you may wonder about this scale. You might think that the love for God falls under the category of love for abstract ideas and principles. You may also wonder that I did not mention the love for God as the highest level of the human scale. You see, my friends, love for God can be healthy and genuine. It can as well be an escape. If it is healthy and genuine, it manifests through the love for others with whom one can communicate and relate to. This, in turn, cannot happen unless you overcome your own fears and vanities, unless you find and dissolve the obstructions in you that cause inability and unwillingness to love. It does not need to be a preoccupation for man -- with the inconceivable and incomprehensible existence of the Creator of all beings. He will have the humility to admit the limitation of such understanding and turn attention to those things human beings can learn, give to, and love -- namely, other human beings. So it is possible, as I often said, that an avowed nonbeliever is really closer to loving God than a professed believer in that the former may not shy away from taxing involvement and mutual growth through it, while the latter may hide his escapism by an unhealthy preoccupation with an abstract God idea he cannot ever really understand through mental processes. The only way he can come closer to an experience of God is through inner growth and liberation of feelings, perception, and determination.

If God is not an inner experience derived through self-development, but rather the pursuit of an idea or ideal, it falls under the category of love for abstract ideas or principles and is, as such, of lesser value than the intimate human relationship of human love that requires practical consideration and the flexibility of putting one's egocentric aims behind those of the other person. To love God as an idea does not require any of this, but to love Him through a fellow creature does. Through deep understanding of the self, the understanding of others grows; and through that, a perception of the divine.

An intense relationship that is often turbulent because of blind egocentricity, selfishness, possessiveness may certainly appear to be the product of a less evolved human being than the semblance of a person who seems very serene, who does many good works for humanity, but who lives a life secluded from personal involvement. It may indeed be true that the latter actually is more developed in general, but in this area where he avoids close involvement, he surely needs to learn. It may be true that the person whose immaturity shows in a stormy relationship may indeed be more immature, may indeed have a troubled soul. But he, at least, is truly in the midst of life and is not avoiding its lessons even if he cannot or will not understand these lessons yet. Nevertheless, the experience itself will in the end be what counts because then the way will be open to properly evaluate and assimilate it, to sort out error from truth, proper perception from misinterpretation.

How can you perceive that there is something amiss if you do not expose yourself to experience that which you may perhaps fear even while you also desire it to some degree? How can you raise your perception, how can you free your scope of determination, how can you purify your capacity of loving if you do not go through and face the impure, self-centered form of love you are now capable of? By avoiding it, you do not grow out of it.

All of you who persevere in this pathwork know that you indeed do what is most essential. Go on searching even though at times you feel discouraged. You will not regret it, provided you do so wholeheartedly and not because you fulfill an unpleasant duty.

Those of you who have not as yet ventured into the path, think about your anxieties and insecurity and realize in what ways you try to assuage them. See how you try to run away from yourself. This may perhaps induce you to seek a more reliable remedy for what really ails you. The most beautiful prayers, the loftiest thoughts can never replace utter self-facing and making conscious that which heretofore slumbered in the hidden recesses of your soul.

And now, my friends, to your questions.

QUESTION: Do you consider that the introverted person is the person who withdraws from life, or do you consider the introverted person as normal?

ANSWER: You see, my dear, here we are dealing with terminology. Some terms have a different meaning for different people or different schools of thought. The word introverted may mean, to some people, introspection, looking within. To others, it may mean being withdrawn from the outer world. In the latter case, I do not have to elaborate any further. But in case you mean the word in the former sense, I say it very much depends on the how, never on the what. If we are preoccupied with the what, we will surely run the risk of misunderstanding and erroneous, confused, unclear thinking. If we remain focused on the how, we will gain clarity. If introversion leads to facing oneself and then utilizing the material to become more whole, better equipped to deal with feelings, with others, better able to expand, then introversion is healthy.

In other words, if this healthy introversion leads to healthy extroversion, it is exactly what true growth means. If self-preoccupation is fruitless, unconstructive, and revolves around the same pointless thoughts, complaints, self-pity, self-deceptive ideas, and subterfuges it will, of necessity, have the result of drawing a wall of isolation around the person indulging in his destructive activity of mind. It is indeed escapism. But by the same token, the extroverted person, as well, can escape and run from himself. His extroversion will never take the form of true relating. The extroverted person can be introspective as well. In other words, any healthy person is a balance of these two directions of being. A preponderance of one is surely a sign of imbalance. Introspection must lead to outgoingness, to spontaneity, to reaching out to others. This, in turn, must be assimilated, digested, evaluated so as to enrich the soul and learn the lessons life has to offer. This period will, again, enable the person to cope even better with the outer world and to joyfully involve himself in life. This alternating rhythm is truly an expression of life, of harmony, of the entire movement of the universe that you can find all through nature. It is in the breathing of the body, in the planets, in the waves of the ocean. It is in the physical manifestation of the cosmos as well as in the mental, emotional, and spiritual waves of being.

Real self-searching will never make a person self-centered and withdrawn. If this is the effect, the work of self-confrontation is somehow off. Such a person needs guidance to set him on the right track.

QUESTION: I would like to ask if you have a special message for a friend?

ANSWER: I cannot add anything more than I have already told him. He is blessed and guided. I can only repeat and emphasize that he has grown more than he may realize. There is much in him that he can utilize, but in a relaxed way with no pressure and strain on the thought process. Rather, he should release all the material of growth that has accumulated in him. It will bring him joy, more and more.

And I say to all of you, man has so often such a distorted view about the essential issues of life -- such faulty perception, such wrong values! What man so often considers "bad" is the best from a wider spectrum, from a point of view of reality. And what man considers favorable and "good" may, in reality, be the most unfavorable occurrence. Only gradually will your view readjust to a more appropriate perception of life.

So often, you are potentially ready to gain a glimpse of reality, to experience its beauty and wisdom, but the fetters of your habit in thinking and feeling prevent you from shedding these shackles. You may even feel somewhat guilty in doing so because so many of you are burdened with a mistaken concept that only heavy thoughts and feelings indicate a depth and profoundness of personality. It may seem frivolous to rejoice in the brighter aspects of reality in which all is as it should be. If you would only allow the growth that has taken place in you to manifest, these perceptions are so much more reliable than your often superimposed, "good," obsolete reactions and responses. Let the gathered inner maturity come out instead of pushing it back because of false concepts you cling to without realizing it. Part of the work on the path is also the finding of unpleasant, faulty aspects of yourself that are painful, humiliating, and unflattering. All of you have by now learned that this unpleasant moment need not last long if you proceed. But part of the pathwork is the finding of true values, of constructive inclinations, of thoughts and feelings that you held down artificially because you erroneously believe them to be wrong. Self-acceptance for inherent value is sometimes as difficult or even more difficult than facing destructiveness. This may be so for a variety of reasons we will look into some other time. For now, suffice it to say that you should be on the lookout for that.

You so often disrupt inner security by artificially courting wrong values and fearing uncertainty that need not be feared. So often, negative feelings are artificially encouraged, while the real you is free of them. This real you may be, at times, quite far away. But it may also, at other times, be much nearer than you make allowance for.

QUESTION: Would the acceptance of reality be a prerequisite for love?

ANSWER: Yes, indeed. I think this very lecture dealt with this very point. I would say it works both ways. If you can accept reality, you are surely more capable of loving. And if, through your inner growth, through facing yourself in complete candor, through dispensing with all defenses and resistances, you reach a point of love capacity, you simultaneously become much better equipped to accept reality. Your resistance to accept that which seems to you unpleasant reality is the same energy current that, if released, is the power of love. Negative emotions are a result of closing the door to reality and to loving. That both are interdependent is evident for they are really both the same. Faulty perception means not being or not seeing reality. Warm, outgoing feelings of affection, concern, understanding are an outcome of the true perception of reality factors, and they simultaneously lead to an increase in perceiving reality in an ever widening circle in width and depth.

The more this is the case, the less can such productive feelings be replaced by a false and weakening sentimentality. When fear of true deep feelings vanishes, the psyche no longer needs to produce false "positive" feelings. This fear is a result of self-centeredness which is the opposite of love. And this same self-centeredness is therefore responsible for creating false, unreal "good feelings." This is another angle that shows you how the equation has to come out, from any way you look at it.

One of the most important aspects of faulty perception of reality is man's belief that he may be quite healthy in one respect while being in conflict, while having problems in another area of his personality. This is quite impossible. One affliction must to some degree affect other personality areas. One thing is intimately connected with another. If you have, for instance, difficulty in making decisions, if you believe yourself very limited in the scope of decisions you make while perhaps overestimating your possibilities in other respects, such an impaired determination must definitely affect all other personality traits and attitudes. If you have difficulty in relating and coping with certain types of people, avoiding them will not remove the problem because this difficulty, expressed in your discomfort, again affects all other manifestations and expressions of your life. It is for that reason that all discomforts should be heeded as a warning signal rather than be avoided. Such reactions prove the error of your still being convinced that your psyche, your entire personality in fact, is divided into many little compartments, of which some of them are healthy and fine, while others are distorted and conflicted. This faulty perception surely shows how limited man's view of reality is. The connection and interdependence has to be established if you really want to grow out of your blindness and enslavement. Of course, in some aspects of life you function relatively well, but you do not realize how the obvious problems affect even the healthy areas because the only way you can judge is by comparison with sicker areas. You cannot imagine the feeling of joy, peace, and security that is the result of a full and thorough will to face oneself. Then the interconnection will gradually become clear and will afford a clearer view of reality where it concerns you. And this is the only way you can begin.

The foregoing should not be misinterpreted to mean that you have to reach a stage of utter health before you can function well, love, perceive, and determine. You can reach a stage or relative advancement in this respect by the mere fact of recognizing your problems in their entire significance. That, of course, is not easy. This realization must not be confused with a quick, glib formulation of a part of the problem you have found. It must be a deep awareness, a transcending experience of comprehension of all your outer problems, hurts, unfulfillments, frustrations as a result of your inner misconception and subsequent faulty responses to life and to other people. When this goal has been achieved, the building-up process can begin. But long before you have truly shed the faulty reactions that are so ingrained, you will be in control of your fate because you now really and profoundly perceive yourself in relationship to your life. By such understanding, you bring fresh, clean air into all the channels that for so long were clogged up with error and confusion. This is the real security I have discussed.

In our next meeting, I shall not only deal with questions regarding the last lecture but also, if there is sufficient time, with any questions that could not be asked after the lectures.

Offhand, the lecture I gave tonight may seem a repetition and a consolidation of some of the material from the past. And yet when you look deeper into this topic, you will surely realize a new depth of understanding of yourself. You will then see that this is, in a sense, quite new because you would not have been able to understand this material and to apply it to yourself only a little while

ago. Those who do not succeed now will certainly do so later, as has so often been the case with my friends. But some of my friends are quite ready now if they will but take the trouble to meditate about it.

May these words take root in you. May the new friends also have found something that may eventually become a seed in their soul.

A stream of love envelopes all of you. May it revivify you. Be in peace. Be in God!

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